

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT
POLICY MANUAL
VOLUME 3
Policy: 301.10 Personal Protective Equipment

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PURPOSE

The Personal Protective Equipment Policy provides personnel guidelines for wearing and using personal protective clothing/equipment.

POLICY

Calimesa Fire Department shall provide for the purchase, repair or replacement of personal protective clothing/equipment as needed. All safety clothing/equipment purchased by the Calimesa Fire Department shall remain the property of the Calimesa Fire Department.

Personnel shall don full body protection prior to responding to a fire scene, traffic collision scene, EMS incident or hazardous environment or situation. Helmets may be donned upon arrival on scene.

Personal protective clothing/equipment issued to personnel shall be properly cleaned and maintained. Helmets will be maintained so as not to have soot on them. Inspections and cleaning will parallel the requirements as stipulated by OSHA and NFPA requirements and guidelines.

Lost or damaged safety clothing/equipment will be reported to the individual's immediate supervisor and documented on a "Lost or Damaged Form (Form 102.03).

STRUCTURE FIREFIGHTING GEAR

Helmet shall be compliant with NFPA and OSHA standards. Personnel are not to drill holes in their helmets at any time. Employee's last name will be affixed to the back of the helmet in reflective tape of a contrasting color.

- Helmet Color Code:
 - Chief Officer: White
 - Captain: Red
 - Firefighter: Yellow
 - Reserve Firefighter: Yellow
- Goggles shall be compliant with NFPA and OSHA standards.
- Turnout coat/pants:
 - Shall be compliant with NFPA and OSHA standards.
- Turnout boots
 - Shall be compliant with NFPA and OSHA standards.
- Two pair of leather structural firefighting gloves shall be compliant with NFPA and OSHA standards.
- Flash Resistant hood
 - Shall be compliant with NFPA and OSHA standards.

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WILD LAND FIREFIGHTING GEAR

Helmet shall consist of full-brim style with shroud. Employee's last name is to be affixed to back of the helmet in reflective tape of a contrasting color.

- Helmet color code:
 - o Chief Officer: white
 - o Captain: red
 - o Firefighter: yellow
 - o Reserve Firefighter: yellow
- Goggles: Shall be compliant with NFPA.
- Wildland jacket: Shall be compliant with NFPA.
- Long sleeve 100% T-shirt that will be worn under the brush jacket that do not have the brush jackets with the lined sleeves.
- Wildland pants: Shall be compliant with NFPA.
- One pair of leather wild land gloves: Shall be compliant with NFPA.
- Fire shelter

Every quarter the Company Officer will conduct a Protective Clothing Inspection and fill out the Safety Protective Clothing Inspection Form (form 402.15).

Inspections and cleaning will parallel the requirements as stipulated by OSHA and NFPA requirements and guidelines.

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PURPOSE

High noise levels can injure employees' hearing. OSHA requires employers having noise levels above permitted levels to have a Hearing Conservation Program in effect.

POLICY

In accordance with Cal-OSHA Title 8, Section 5097, the employer shall administer a continuing, effective hearing conservation program whenever employee noise exposures equal or exceed an 8-hour time weighted average (TWA) sound level of 85 decibels measured on the A-scale (slow response).

The Program's components are as follows:

- Survey all facilities and identify areas where you believe there is a high noise level.
- Conduct a sound level test at each high noise level site.
- If the sound level is above 85 dB(a), you need to determine how long the noise is at that level or above.
- Mount noise dosimeters on each of the effected employees and keep them on for a full 8-hour day. You are looking to see how much noise the effected employees are exposed to during this time period.

Compare your results to the following chart providing you with the permitted duration per workday for the level of noise an employee is exposed to.

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Table N-1 Permissible Noise Exposures (1)
(Samples from this Table)

Permitted Duration Per Workday (Hours)	Sound Level dB(a) Slow Response
8	90
6	92
4	95
3	97
2	100
1-1/2	102
1	105
1/2	110
1/4 or less	115

Footnote (1):

When the daily noise exposure is composed of two or more periods of noise exposure of different levels, their combined effect should be considered, rather than the individual effect of each.

Exposure to impulsive or impact noise should not exceed 140 dB peak sound pressure level.

Engineer or Isolate the Noise

If you can reduce (attenuate) the noise below the 85 dB(a) level, you will not have to create a full-scale Hearing Conservation Program. Otherwise, you will have to continue with the implementation of this program.

Ongoing monitoring must be done whenever there is a change in:

- Production,
- Process,
- Equipment,
- Controls,
- There is a perceived change in noise levels.

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The purpose of ongoing monitoring is to ascertain whether:

Additional employees may be exposed, and/or the attenuation provided by hearing protectors being used might be inadequate to meet the new noise levels of:

- Baseline Audiometric Tests
- Annual Audiometric Tests
- Administrative Controls (job rotation, breaks)
- Personal Protective Equipment

EMPLOYEE TRAINING

Initial and annual training must be given to employees who are involved in the Hearing Conservation Program. Employees must be informed of:

- The effects of noise on hearing.
- The purpose of hearing protectors to include:
 - Advantages
 - Disadvantages
- Attenuation of the different types of protectors plus instructions on
- Selection
- Fitting
- Use and Care
- Postings

Article 105 of Title 8, Control of Noise Exposure, shall be made available to all employees, and it shall be posted on employee bulletin boards.

RECORD KEEPING

The following documents must be maintained:

- Exposure measurements (2 years)
- Audiometric testing (Duration of the affected employee's employment)
- Audiometric Test Rooms (fully described within the standard)

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PURPOSE

This program has been developed to comply with Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA) regulation 29 CFR 1910.95 and NFPA 1500 to ensure the prevention of occupational hearing loss for all Fire Department employees.

The permissible exposure level for Calimesa Fire Department Hearing Conservation Program (HCP) is 85 decibels A-weighted (dB(a)). All employees exposed at or above 85 dB(a) over an 8- hour time-weighted average (TWA) period, are required to wear hearing protection.

This program has established a noise "Action Level," defined as 82 decibels on the A- weighted scale (dB(a)), slow response, for an 8-hour time weighted average (TWA) period, or equivalently, a dose of 50%, based on an exchanged rate of 3 decibels (dB). All employees exposed to noise levels at or above this level must participate in this program.

IDENTIFICATION OF PURPOSE

This program applies to all fire personnel who respond to fires and EMS calls on a regular basis. The associated work tasks on fire and emergency medical scenes are suspected of exposing employees to noise levels at or above 82 dB(a) as an 8 hour TWA.

IDENTIFICATION OF WORK AREAS

Fire Department personnel shall wear hearing protection whenever exposed to noise at or above 85 decibels.

The following work areas have been identified as requiring hearing protection:

- While riding in Fire apparatus under Code 3 and normal driving conditions.
- All training activities that generate noise from sledgehammers, saws or any other fire equipment.

IDENTIFICATION OF EQUIPMENT

Fire Department personnel are required to wear hearing protection when operating equipment that produces noise in excess of 85 decibels except in situations where the use of such personal protective equipment would create an additional hazard to the user. Identified equipment includes but is not limited to the following:

- Apparatus Pumps
- Extrication Equipment
- Circular Saws
- Air Chisels

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MONITORING

OSHA requires employers to monitor noise exposure levels in a manner that will accurately identify employees who are exposed to noise at or above 82 dB averaged over 8 working hours, or an 8-hour TWA.

The exposure measurement must include all continuous, intermittent and impulsive noise within an 80 dB - 130 dB range and must be representative of a typical work situation.

Monitoring should be repeated when changes in production, process or controls increase noise exposure. Such changes may mean that additional employee monitoring is needed and/or previously supplied hearing protection no longer provides adequate attenuation.

HEARING PROTECTION

Hearing protectors must be made available to all workers exposed to 8-hour TWA noise levels of 82 dB(a) or above.

Types of hearing protectors selected for employee protection must attenuate the noise to levels less than 85 dB(a).

Where equipment operators are required to maintain radio communications while operating equipment, headsets that provide noise attenuation as well as radio communications/intercom shall be provided and used.

The wearing of hearing protection devices by employees will be mandatory under the following conditions:

- Wearing the hearing protection device does not create an additional hazard to the user.
- Employees who are exposed to average noise levels at an 8-hour time weighted average of 85 dB(a) or above.
- Employees who have not had a baseline audiogram and are exposed to 8-hour average noise levels of 85 dB(a) or above.
 - Employees who have experienced a standard threshold shift (STS).

TRAINING

Fire Department employees exposed to an 8-hour time-weighted average noise of 82 dB(a) and above shall be trained annually in the effects of noise; the purpose of hearing protectors; the advantages and disadvantages of the various types of hearing protectors; the selection, fitting and care of protectors

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AUDIOMETRIC TESTING

Annual audiometric testing of all employees exposed to 8-hour time weighted-average noise of 82 dBA or above will be conducted as part of the annual employee physical.

All new employees shall be given an initial baseline audiometric exam, which is performed during the pre-employment physical for new employees.

Employees should be reminded to avoid exposure to loud levels of noise for at least 14 hours prior to the audiometric exam. If the employee believes that exposure to noise is unavoidable for this 14-hour period, he/she shall be instructed to wear hearing protection while exposed to noise.

STANDARD THRESHOLD SHIFT - FOLLOW-UP PROCEDURES

A standard threshold shift (STS) is a change in hearing threshold relative to the baseline audiogram of an average of 10 dB or more at 2000, 3000 and 4000 Hz in either ear.

Fire employees who have a suspected standard threshold shift (as defined above) indicated on the audiometric exam report, must have a retest within 30 days.

If the second audiometric exam, performed within 30 days of the first test, confirms a standard threshold shift, the affected employee shall be notified by the Fire Chief in writing within 21 days of this determination.

Unless a physician determines that the standard threshold shift is not work-related or aggravated by occupational noise exposure, the following steps must be taken:

- Employees not wearing hearing protectors shall be fitted with hearing protectors, trained in their use and care, and required to use them provided that the use does not create an additional hazard.
- Employees already using hearing protectors shall be refitted and retrained in the use of hearing protectors and provided with hearing protectors offering greater attenuation, if necessary.

RECORD KEEPING

Noise exposure measurement records shall be retained for five (5) years.

Employees with standard threshold shifts - STS- (25 dB shifts in hearing acuity) averaged over the frequencies at 2000, 3000 and 4000 hertz in either ear will be considered to have a CAL-OSHA reportable injury. This injury shall be included on the CAL-OSHA 300 Log. STSs will be determined by annual audiometric testing.

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Effective January 1, 2004, employees with standard threshold shifts - STS - (10 dB shifts in hearing acuity) averaged over the frequencies at 2000, 3000 and 4000 hertz in either ear which results in a total 25 dB level of hearing above audiometric zero will be considered to have an CAL-OSHA reportable injury which must be recorded on the OSHA 300 Log by checking the "hearing loss" column.

Records of audiometric test results shall be maintained in their personal files for the duration of employment of the affected employee plus 30 years.

Audiometric test records must include the name and job classification of the employee, the date of the test, the name of the examiner, the date of acoustic calibration of the testing equipment, background sound pressure levels in the audiometric test room, and the employee's most recent noise exposure measurements.

Records of annual training shall be maintained in the Fire Department Administration Office.

DEFINITIONS

Action Level: The sound level when reached or exceeded necessitates implementation of activities to reduce the risk of noise-induced hearing loss. The City of Calimesa currently uses an 8-hour TWA of 82 dB(a) as the criterion for implementing an effective Hearing Conservation Program.

Attenuation: The estimated sound protection provided by hearing protective devices as worn in "real-world" environments.

Equal-Energy Rule: The relationship between sound level and sound duration based upon a 3 dB exchange rate i.e., the sound energy resulting from doubling or halving a noise exposure's duration is equivalent to increasing or decreasing the sound level by 3dB respectively.

Exchange Rate: The relationship between intensity and dose. The city of Calimesa uses a 3 dB exchange rate. Thus, if the intensity of an exposure increases by 3dB, the dose doubles (i.e., if a 50% dose represents a sound intensity of 82 dB, then increasing that intensity by 3dB, to 85 dB, would double the dose, to 100%).